

Is a Translation Degree Worth It in the AI Era? The 2026 Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

8.8

AI EXPOSURE · GENERAL DOCUMENT TRANSLATION
where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

Quick answer: General document translation scores **8.8 out of 10** for AI exposure — the highest score of any career in this index, where 10 is most at risk. But court and medical interpreting scores **4.3**. **Same languages, same training, a 4.5-point gap.** Translation is the profession where the automation has largely already happened, which makes it the most instructive career we score.

The short answer for parents: not as a route to translating documents. That work is effectively gone and has been for several years. Interpreting — a human physically present, legally accountable, in a room where it matters — is a different and genuinely protected career that happens to use the same languages.

Translation AI risk score by track

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to an interpreter and a paramedic.

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVE	BAND
Community / medical interpreting	3.5	3.9	4.3	+0.8	Low–Moderate
Legal / court interpreting	3.6	3.9	4.3	+0.7	Low–Moderate
Conference / simultaneous interpreting	4.2	4.6	5.1	+0.9	Moderate
Literary translation	5.9	6.5	7.0	+1.1	High
Localization / technical translation	7.1	7.7	8.2	+1.1	High
General document translation	7.7	8.4	8.8	+1.1	Highest in the index

2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.

How that compares: the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. Graphic design production scores **8.4**. Entry-level software development scores **8.1**. Bedside nursing scores **2.8**.

Two things to notice. The 4.5-point internal spread is the widest of any profession we score. And document translation was already at 7.7 in 2023 — this automation did not begin with the current wave. It largely finished during it.

Will AI replace translators?

For most written translation, it substantially already has.

AI IS TAKING	IT CAN'T TOUCH
Document and business translation	Being physically present in a courtroom
Website and software localization	Reading a frightened patient's meaning, not just their words
Subtitling and transcription	Legal accountability for an accurate rendering
Technical manuals and specifications	Simultaneous interpreting under live pressure
First-draft literary translation	Cultural judgment where the stakes are personal
Multilingual content production	Being the person a non-English speaker trusts in the room

This is not a forecast. Machine translation crossed the threshold of commercial usability years ago, rates for general translation work collapsed accordingly, and the profession restructured around post-editing rather than translating.

Why the enormous split? The six factors

How general document translation rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

FACTOR	RATING	EFFECT ON RISK
How much of this job can AI already do?	9.5	↑ the highest rating we assign
How hard will it be to land that first job?	9.0	↑ severe exposure
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	1.0	↓ none
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	2.5	↓ almost none
Does the law require a licensed human?	1.0	↓ none
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	2.5	↓ almost none

ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

So you can see *what the analysis actually looks like* — in the one profession where the automation is essentially complete.

How much of this job can AI already do? — rated 9.5, and this is what a finished automation looks like

Every other high score in this index is a forecast about a process underway. Translation is not. It is a report on something that has already happened, which makes it the most useful case study we have.

Text-to-text conversion is the single task these systems were built for. Not adjacent to it, not an application of it — the thing itself. Take language in, produce equivalent language out. There is no profession more directly in the path of the technology, and the results are visible in the market rather than in projections: rates for general translation fell, agencies restructured around post-editing machine output, and the job title that survived is "post-editor" rather than "translator."

We rate it 9.5 rather than 10 because a human still reviews high-stakes output, and because some domains resist — legally binding text, marketing that must land culturally, anything where an error is expensive.

Now look at the other end of the same profession. Court interpreting rates 6.5 on this factor — still substantial, but far lower, and it scores 4.3 rather than 8.8. What changed?

The interpreter is physically present in a room (6.5 on physical, against 1.0). Someone is legally accountable for an accurate rendering, and in many jurisdictions certified (7.5 on regulatory,

against 1.0). A defendant or patient is trusting a specific human at a moment that matters (8.0 on trust, against 2.5).

Same languages. Same skill. Entirely different job, because of where it happens and who is answerable for it.

The general lesson, and it is the single most transferable finding in this index: when a profession's core task is converting one form of text into another, expect no protection at all. When the same expertise is applied in a room, with a person, under accountability, expect a great deal. The question to ask of any career is not "what do you know?" but where do you have to be, and who answers for it?

Which language careers are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **Community / medical interpreting** — 4.3. Physical presence, vulnerable people, high consequence for error. 2. **Legal / court interpreting** — 4.3. Certification requirements and legal accountability for accuracy. 3. **Conference / simultaneous interpreting** — 5.1. Live, high-pressure, in the room — though remote and AI-assisted formats are advancing. 4. **Literary translation** — 7.0. Genuine craft, but the first draft is now machine-generated in most workflows. 5. **Localization / technical** — 8.2. Restructured around post-editing. 6. **General document translation** — 8.8. Essentially automated.

Is a languages degree still worth it in 2026?

Not as vocational training for translation. Almost certainly yes for other reasons.

The translation career specifically has been hollowed out, and honest programs should say so. A degree sold as preparation for translating documents is preparing students for the most automated work in this index.

But a languages degree was never only that. Fluency plus a domain remains genuinely valuable — international law, diplomacy, global health, trade, security, and any field where being able to operate in another culture rather than merely convert its text is the point. Interpreting is a real and protected career requiring specific additional training.

The distinction worth teaching a student: **AI has largely solved translation and has not solved communication.** Knowing what a sentence means is now free. Knowing what should be said, to whom, in what register, in a room where it matters, is not.

Worth asking any program: what proportion of graduates work in language-specific roles, and does the curriculum train interpreting and cultural competence or only written translation?

Common questions

Will AI replace translators? For general written translation, it substantially has. The market restructured around post-editing several years ago, and rates fell accordingly.

Is translation a dead career? Written translation is the most exposed work we score at 8.8. Interpreting is a genuinely different career at 4.3, protected by presence and accountability.

Is interpreting safe from AI? Much safer than translation. Court and medical interpreting involve a physically present, often certified human who is accountable for accuracy in a setting where errors have serious consequences.

Should my child study languages? Yes if the goal is fluency plus a domain, or interpreting. No if the goal is translating documents for a living.

What is the highest-risk career in your index? General document translation, at 8.8 — ahead of graphic design production at 8.4 and entry-level software development at 8.1.

Related careers

- **Graphic & visual design** — 8.4 production, 5.6 creative direction
 - **Journalism & media** — 8.3 desk, 5.1 investigative
 - **Marketing & communications** — 8.2 content execution, 5.5 brand strategy
 - **Law** — 7.9 junior associate, 4.5 trial advocacy
 - **Nursing** — 2.8, and the clearest contrast in structural protection
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What's in the translation Career Value Guide

This sampler tells you where translation stands. The full Career Value Guide tells you what to do about it.

	SAMPLER	CAREER VALUE GUIDE
Verdict, all track scores, 3-year trend	✓	✓
Six-factor ratings	✓	✓
Reasoning behind every factor rating	one example	✓
How durable each protection is — including remote interpreting		✓
What actually happened to the translation market — and what it predicts elsewhere		✓
The honest downsides — rates, freelance precarity, certification costs		✓
What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits		✓
The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening		✓
Routes in — interpreting certification, domain pairing, diplomacy and law		✓
Where a languages degree leads — beyond translation		✓
Program evaluation checklist — interpreting training, cultural competence		✓
Questions to ask a program — plus red flags		✓
Sourced further reading		✓
Discussion questions for parent and student		✓
A short version written directly to the student		✓
Technical scoring appendix		✓

GET THE CAREER VALUE GUIDE

Most families are weighing two or three careers seriously, and a few more they haven't ruled out. Pick the ones you need.

1 career	\$49	Choose →
3 careers	\$69	Choose →
Unlimited	\$99	Choose →

Each Career Value Guide includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. This edition and the next are included — we re-score every six months, so what you buy stays current for a year.

[Read a complete Career Value Guide free →](#) We publish one Career Value Guide in full, openly, so you can judge the depth before buying anything. Computer science is the one to read — it's the most surprising result in the index.

Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.